



Ehren, who took charge in 2020, the Red Panthers went from a bottom-half side in the Pro League to a consistent top-half team, before making the Olympic semifinals for the first time in their history.

After Ehren left the post in 2024 on a sour note, Adam Commens, long embedded in the Belgian hockey set-up, stepped up to lead the side to successive third-place finishes in the Pro League.

Belgium will hope to cash in on any home advantage, even though it lost five of its eight matches at Wavre this year. It has the pace, skill and experience to trouble the field. Midfielder Alix Gerniers remains central to the side and will need

support from fellow experienced players such as Michelle Struijk, Stephanie Vanden Borre and Judith Vandermeiren.

China will be the real dark horse after its stellar rise under Australian head coach Alyson Annan, who led the side to an Olympic runner-up finish sandwiched between Asian Games and Asia Cup titles.

The consistency has carried over against the best teams too, with China finishing fourth in the Pro League in each of the last two seasons.

Defence remains a concern after China shipped 19 goals in four games against the Netherlands, Germany and Belgium, though it has

Dutch weapon: When the Netherlands earns a Penalty Corner, Yibbi Jansen is never far from the equation. GETTY IMAGES

shown it can beat anyone on its day. Attacking play could be the bigger issue in the latter rounds, but midfielder Li Hong, who plays her club hockey in Amsterdam H&BC, will be keen to make her mark against the best in the world.

Mixed Pro League form leaves Germany, Australia and Spain as outsiders for the title. Unlike in 2022, there is no debutant this time, with Ireland, Scotland, Chile and South Africa bracing for a tough outing.